

Clocking Out of AI

USA - Midwest

The Premise

A new boundary is forming between the AI-saturated workplace and the rest of life. Adoption is rising sharply on one side of that line and falling on the other; people are introducing friction and spending real money to keep the line clear.

AI is becoming workwear: what you put on for the office, not what you wear to be yourself.

Why is this important?

The dominant narrative is a single adoption curve going up, and the numbers at work back it: half of US workers now use AI in their role (Gallup, Feb 2026), and frequent white-collar use jumped 12 points to 27% in a single year. The Midwest shows there are actually two curves: one steep at work, one flat or declining at home.

What people choose to do for themselves is increasingly defined as *the opposite* of what they do for their employer, and that gap is becoming a real consumer category.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

AI adoption **at work** is delivering measurable productivity gains.

Meanwhile, consumer trust in AI in **personal/intimate contexts** is collapsing, and the rejection is becoming organized and economic; the "AI ick" is now a culturally legible category. The same people rejecting AI at home are using it daily at work.

Opportunity: recognize that AI isn't a single product strategy- it's context-dependent.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence

- Friction economy is going mainstream ([Light Phone III launches developer SDK](#), [Tin Can hits cultural milestone](#), [Brick sees 600% YoY download surge](#))
- Analog hobbies and craft as the new luxury ([Film order volumes up 127% globally since 2020](#), [Camera store thriving](#), [Penguin Foot Pottery](#) is consistently waitlisted)
- "Made by humans" becoming a premium positioning across industries ([iHeartMedia's "guaranteed human" tagline](#), ["made by humans" as the new premium label](#))
- AI products facing organized public rejection ([#QuitGPT campaign hits 700,000 pledges](#), [Instacart's algorithmic-pricing backlash](#), [Pinterest adds AI-slop filters after user backlash](#))
- The "AI ick" enters mainstream language ([Zara Larsson fans riot over AI reposting](#), [Merriam-Webster names "slop" 2025 Word of the Year](#))

Why did the studio pick this one?

The same observation kept surfacing across our Midwest colleagues, in different forms: 'Bricking', ceramics studios, the rise of "AI ick," **people quietly walling AI out of their personal lives even as they adopt it at work.**

It builds on "Finding Neo" (2026) by showing AI resistance moving from philosophical to behavioral. The Midwest is showing two curves, on the same person, and the gap between them is where a lot of consumer behavior now lives.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

- Companies should figure out which customer moments need to feel human and which can quietly automate; treat AI as a design choice, not a default
 - Let users turn it off in personal moments (cards, gifts, photos, messages) and keep it in functional ones (search, scheduling)
- Audit the AI features no one asked for. Autocomplete, chatbots, generated suggestions - in some categories, they're making the experience worse.
- Don't assume employees love AI at work just because they're using it
 - Internal tools and change programs should acknowledge the gap between mandate and preference